

Traveling by road

The use of wheeled vehicles for movement on land began more than 5,000 years ago. These vehicles were usually pulled by animals (although sometimes people did the hauling themselves). There were various types of early carts and wagons, some of which carried passengers and goods while others were designed for use in warfare.

War wagon

- **What?** Sumerian battle chariot
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Mesopotamia, c. 2500 BCE

The Sumerians, people whose homeland is modern-day Iraq, invented a war wagon with four solid wooden disk wheels. It

was pulled by onagers (Asian animals similar to donkeys) and used to carry important leaders into battle. The wagon also provided a platform on which soldiers armed with javelins could stand.

Early wheeled cart

- **What?** Two-wheeled vehicle
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Mesopotamia, c. 3000 BCE

Among the earliest land vehicles were simple two-wheeled carts that were pulled by one or two large domesticated animals such as oxen or horses. They were developed in several different places, especially Mesopotamia (now mainly in Iraq), the Caucasus (a region between Europe and Asia), and Eastern Europe, at around the same time. Later, the use of wheeled carts spread further, reaching Africa and Asia.



Cart pulled by oxen

Terra-cotta figurine from an ancient site in the Indus Valley (in Pakistan), c. 2400 BCE



War wagon depicted on a decorated box from the ancient Mesopotamian city of Ur, c. 2500 BCE